

COGDELL LAW FIRM

Content Editor's Guide

How to update the website — no coding required

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1. Start here

What the Studio is, and the one rule that matters

This guide is for people who write and update content.

You do not need to know how to code, and nothing in here will ask you to. If you can use a word processor, you can use the Studio.

Everything you read on the Cogdell Law website — every headline, paragraph, photo, attorney bio, testimonial and phone number — is stored in a system called **Sanity Studio**. The website itself has no words of its own. It asks the Studio what to say, and prints it.

That means you can change anything on the site without a developer. It also means a change you make in the Studio is a change to the live website.

The one rule

Your work is private until you press **Publish**. Type as much as you like, save drafts, come back tomorrow — nobody sees any of it. The moment you publish, the website rebuilds itself and your change goes live to the public a couple of minutes later.

Nothing you do is instant, and nothing is lost.

Publishing triggers an automatic rebuild of the site. Give it two or three minutes before you check the live page. If you refresh straight away and the change isn't there, it isn't broken — it just hasn't finished yet.

What you can and can't do

You can:

- Change any words or images on any page
- Add attorneys, practice areas, testimonials, news, podcast episodes, videos and FAQs
- Remove or hide things you no longer want
- Reorder the lists that appear on the site
- Set the title and description that show up in Google

You can't (and shouldn't need to):

- Create a brand-new type of page — the page designs are built in code
- Change colours, fonts or layout
- Delete one of the main pages — they're locked so nobody can remove them by accident

2. Signing in

Getting into the Studio for the first time

The Studio lives at the website's own address with **/admin** on the end. If the site is at **cogdell-law.com**, the Studio is at:

cogdell-law.com/admin

Then:

1. Bookmark that address. You'll use it every time.
2. Choose the sign-in method you were invited with — usually Google, or an email and password.
3. The first time, you may be asked to allow the Studio access to your account. That's normal; approve it.

If it won't let you in

The Studio only opens for people who have been **invited to the project**. Signing in with an account nobody has invited will get you a polite refusal, not an error — it isn't a broken password. Ask whoever manages the site to send you an invitation, and make sure you sign in with the same email address the invitation went to.

Use one account, and keep it to yourself.

The Studio records who changed what. Sharing a login makes that history useless, and it's the first thing anyone looks at when a page changes unexpectedly. If someone new needs access, have them invited properly.

3. How the Studio is organised

Three groups in the left-hand menu — that's the whole map

When you sign in you'll see a column on the left with three entries. Everything in the Studio sits inside one of them.

GROUP	WHAT'S IN IT	HOW MANY
Pages	One entry per page of the website. "Home Page", "Contact Page", "Our Firm Page", and so on — plus a Legal folder holding the Privacy Policy and Disclaimer.	Exactly one of each. You can't add or delete them.
Collections	The things there are lots of: attorney bios, practice areas, testimonials, news articles, podcast episodes, videos, FAQs, trial results, service cities and location pages.	As many as you like. Add and remove freely.
Site Settings	Things that appear on every page: the firm's phone number and address, the call-to-action bar, the consultation form wording, the fact-checked banner, and site-wide search settings.	Exactly one of each.

The difference that matters

Pages hold the wording of one specific page. **Collections** hold records that get *used* by pages. A testimonial isn't a page — it's a record that shows up on the homepage, on the testimonials page, and possibly inside a practice-area page. Write it once, and it appears everywhere it's needed.

Why some things are locked

You'll notice you can't create a second Home Page, and the global "+ Create" button doesn't offer one. That's deliberate — a duplicate would be invisible to the website and would quietly waste your time. The pages that exist are the pages the site has.

Change the phone number in one place.

The number in **Site Settings** → **Firm Details** is the one used in the header, the footer, the contact page and every call-to-action on the site. Change it once and it changes everywhere. This is what Site Settings is for.

4. Editing something

The loop you'll use ninety per cent of the time

1. Click through the left-hand menu until you find what you want — for example **Pages** → **Contact Page**, or **Collections** → **Attorney Bios** → **Dan L. Cogdell**.
2. Change what you want to change. There's no Save button; your typing is kept as you go.
3. Press **Publish** at the bottom of the editor.
4. Wait two or three minutes, then check the live site.

Reading the editor

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT IT MEANS
Tabs across the top	Longer records are split into tabs — usually Content and SEO , sometimes Card and Page . They're all part of the same record. Publishing publishes all of them at once.
Grey text under a field	A note from whoever built the site, explaining what that field is for and where it shows up. Worth reading — they were written for you.
A red message	Something required is missing or wrong. You cannot publish until it's fixed. The message says what's needed.
An orange or yellow message	A suggestion, not a rule — usually "this reads better if you keep it shorter". You can publish anyway. Consider taking the advice.
The Publish button greyed out	Either there's nothing new to publish, or something required is missing. Scroll up and look for red.

Changing your mind

Before you publish, unwanted edits can be thrown away — look for the option to discard your draft or revert your changes in the menu beside the Publish button. After you publish, the Studio keeps a history of the document, so a previous version can be brought back. If you're not sure how, ask before you start clicking — it's much easier to recover a mistake than to undo a well-meant repair.

Publish when you're finished, not as you go.

Every publish rebuilds the whole website. Publishing ten times while you work through a page isn't harmful, but it's noisy and slow. Get the page how you want it, then publish once.

5. Adding something new

Only Collections can grow — and that's most of what you'll add

1. Open the collection you want to add to — say **Collections** → **Testimonials**.
2. Click the + (or "Create new") button at the top of the list.
3. Fill in the fields. Anything the site can't do without will tell you so in red.
4. Press **Publish**.

About slugs

Some records ask for a **slug**. That's the part of the web address that identifies the page — in cogdell-law.com/attorney/osso-anthony, the slug is the highlighted bit.

There's a **Generate** button beside the field that builds one from the title. Use it. Lower-case letters and hyphens only — no spaces, no apostrophes, no capitals.

Never change a slug on a page that's already live.

The slug *is* the address. Change it and the old address stops working: anyone who bookmarked that page, any Google result pointing at it, and any link to it from another website all break at once. If a page genuinely has to move, tell a developer first so a redirect can be put in place.

Things that reference other things

Some fields ask you to pick an existing record rather than type something. A location page picks its **Service City**; a practice area can pick the attorney who **reviewed** it; a sub-topic picks its **Parent Page**. Start typing and the Studio offers matches. If what you need isn't in the list, it doesn't exist yet — go and create it first, then come back.

6. Removing something

Unpublish hides it. Delete destroys it.

OPTION	WHAT HAPPENS	WHEN TO USE IT
Unpublish	The record disappears from the website but stays in the Studio. You can publish it again later and it comes back exactly as it was.	Almost always. An attorney who has left, a seasonal notice, anything you <i>might</i> want back.
Delete	The record is gone from the Studio as well. There's no button that brings it back.	Genuine mistakes — a duplicate, a test entry, something created in the wrong place.

Both live in the menu beside the Publish button, at the bottom of the editor.

If something else is pointing at it, the Studio will stop you.

Try to delete an attorney who is set as the reviewer on three practice-area pages and you'll get a warning listing them. That's the Studio protecting the site, not malfunctioning. Go and clear those references first — or just unpublish instead, which is usually what you actually wanted.

A gentler option: featuring

Testimonials have a **Feature on the homepage** switch. Turning it off doesn't remove the testimonial — it stays on the full testimonials page and simply stops appearing on the homepage. Only **three** can be featured at once, because the homepage grid is three across. Turn one off before you turn another on.

7. Writing text

The rich-text editor, and everything its toolbar can do

Longer fields — an attorney's biography, a practice-area body, an FAQ answer, the Privacy Policy — use a small formatting toolbar. It is deliberately limited, so that anything you write comes out looking like the rest of the site.

CONTROL	WHAT IT'S FOR
Normal	Ordinary paragraphs. This is almost everything you write.
Heading 2 / 3 / 4	Section headings inside the text. Heading 2 for main sections, Heading 3 beneath it, Heading 4 for the rare third level. There is no Heading 1 — the big title at the top of the page is already the Heading 1, and a second one confuses Google.
Quote	Pulls a passage out as a styled quotation with a decorative quote mark.
Bold / Italic	As you'd expect. Use bold sparingly — a page where everything is emphasised reads as though nothing is.
Link	Select the words first, then add the link. For a page on this site, type the path only: /contact , not the full address. For another website, paste the whole address including https:// .
Bulleted / Numbered list	Numbered lists are for genuine sequences — steps in a process. Use bullets for everything else.

Don't paste straight from Word.

Word and Google Docs smuggle invisible formatting into anything you copy, and it can arrive looking wrong in ways that are tedious to clean up. Paste as plain text (**Cmd+Shift+V** on a Mac, **Ctrl+Shift+V** on Windows), then apply headings and bold in the Studio.

8. Adding images

Upload once, and let the site do the work

Drag a file onto an image field, or click it and choose one. The site automatically produces every size it needs and serves each visitor the smallest one that will still look sharp — so upload the **largest, best quality version you have**. It's far better to give the site a big image and let it shrink it than to give it a small one it has to stretch.

The hotspot

The same photo gets cropped differently in different places — square on a card, tall beside a quote, wide behind a heading. Click **Edit hotspot** (the crop icon) and drag the circle over the part that must never be cut off, usually a face. Every crop on the site is then built around that point.

Alt text

Where a field asks for **alt text**, describe what the picture shows, in a plain sentence. "Dan Cogdell speaking to reporters outside the courthouse" — not "photo", not "IMG_4821", and not a list of keywords.

Alt text is read aloud to people who can't see the image.

It's also what Google reads. Writing it well takes ten seconds and helps two audiences at once. Where the image is purely decorative — a background texture behind a heading — leaving it blank is the correct answer, not a lazy one.

9. The special blocks

Practice-area and location pages can hold more than text

On **Practice Areas** and **Location Pages** only, the body field lets you drop designed sections into the middle of your writing. Look for the **Insert** or **+** control in the editor, and choose one of five:

BLOCK	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE
CTA Banner	A dark band with a heading, a supporting line and up to two buttons. For "Speak to a defence lawyer today" moments.
Get In Touch Bar	A slim bar with a short heading and a phone number, set large. Good roughly halfway down a long page.
Attorney Card	Pick an attorney; the site pulls in their photo and details. You add a short passage and up to two buttons.
Attorney Quote	Pick an attorney and write a quotation attributed to them. Their portrait sits alongside it.
Client Testimonial	Pick an existing testimonial and it appears as a styled card. You don't retype it — it stays linked to the original.

These blocks only exist on those two page types.

If you're editing an attorney bio, an FAQ answer, a news article or a legal page and can't find the Insert menu, that's why — those pages are plain text by design. It isn't a fault, and it isn't something you're missing.

Used sparingly, these blocks break up a long page and give a reader somewhere to act. Three banners in a row is worse than none: the reader stops seeing them.

10. Putting things in order

Six lists you can drag — and what the rest do

In these six collections, the order you set in the Studio is the order the website uses. Drag a record by its handle to move it.

- **Attorney Bios** — the order they appear on the homepage and /attorneys
- **Practice Areas** — the order in the navigation menu and on the cards
- **Service Cities** — the order cities are grouped in
- **Location Pages** — the order within each city
- **Videos** — the order on the videos page
- **FAQs** — the order questions are answered in

The remaining collections — Testimonials, News Articles, Podcast Episodes and Trial Results — aren't dragged. They're arranged by the page that uses them, usually newest first, or by a field on the record itself.

A new record lands at the bottom.

Create a new attorney and they'll appear last on the page until you drag them where they belong. It's easy to publish and wonder why the new bio is nowhere to be seen — scroll down.

11. The SEO tab

Five fields, and permission to ignore most of them

Most records have an **SEO** tab. Everything on it is optional. Leave it empty and the site works out sensible values from the page's own title and summary — which is often the right answer.

FIELD	WHAT IT DOES	FILL IT IN?
Meta title	The clickable blue line in Google's results. Aim for around 60 characters.	When the page's own heading is too long or too vague to work as a search result.
Meta description	The grey summary underneath it. Around 155 characters.	Worth writing for important pages. It's your advert in the search results.
Canonical URL	Tells Google that this page is really a copy of another one.	Leave blank. Getting it wrong hides the page from Google. Ask a developer.
Hide from search engines	Asks Google not to list this page at all.	Only for a page you deliberately want unlisted.
Social share image	The picture shown when the page is shared on Facebook or LinkedIn.	Optional. A site-wide default is used when it's empty.

Write for a person, not for a search engine.

A meta description that reads like a sentence someone would say will always outperform one stuffed with "Houston criminal defense attorney lawyer Houston TX". Google has been ignoring that for over a decade.

12. Where everything lives

If you know what you want to change, start here

Pages

OPEN THIS	TO CHANGE
Home Page	The whole homepage, section by section: the hero, selling points, practice-area band, About, statement band, attorneys, firm story, testimonials, why-choose-us, reach map, press logos, FAQ and news band.
Trial Experience Page	The trial-experience page's heading and wording. The cases themselves are in Trial Results .
Testimonials Page	Headings and intro for the testimonials page. The quotes are in Testimonials .
Attorneys Page	Headings and intro for the attorneys page. The people are in Attorney Bios .
Our Firm Page	The firm story, values and founding-attorney sections.
Practice Areas Page	The heading and intro above the practice-area grid.
News Page	The heading above the news grid. Articles are in News Articles .
Podcast Page	The podcast page heading and intro. Episodes are in Podcast Episodes .
Videos Page	The heading above the video grid. Videos are in Videos .
Contact Page	The contact page's wording.
Legal → Privacy Policy	The privacy policy text.
Legal → Disclaimer	The disclaimer text.

Collections

OPEN THIS	TO CHANGE
Attorney Bios	Each attorney: name, role, card blurb, photo, phone, email, biography, education, publications and speaking. Gives them a page at <code>/attorney/name</code> .
Practice Areas	Each practice area and sub-topic. Parent Page is what nests one inside another and builds the web address. Holds the page body, its FAQs and the attorney who reviewed it.
Service Cities	The cities the firm serves. A city is a grouping label — it has no page of its own.
Location Pages	A page for one service in one city. Picks its city, and has its own hero, body and FAQs.
Videos	Title plus the Wistia ID. The thumbnail and running time come from Wistia automatically — you don't type them.
FAQs	Question-and-answer pairs for the site-wide FAQ section. (Practice areas keep their own separate FAQs.)
Testimonials	Client quotes and attribution, plus the Feature on the homepage switch — maximum three.
News Articles	Press mentions. Either a link out to coverage elsewhere, or a full article hosted on this site — the This item field decides which.
Podcast Episodes	Episode title, number, tag, artwork, show notes, the Spotify link, and the chapter list.
Trial Results	Case name, outcome, write-up, which filter group it belongs to, and an optional shorter version for the homepage.

Site Settings

OPEN THIS	TO CHANGE
Firm Details	Firm name, tagline, phone, email, office address, social links, logo, copyright line and footer legal links. The address also drives the footer map.
Call-to-Action Bar	The default call-to-action band. Individual pages can override it.
Consultation Form	The wording around the consultation form.
Fact-Checked Banner	The small "fact-checked" badge wording.
Global SEO Settings	The site-wide default share image, and the crawling switch.

13. Please be careful with these

Five things that are easy to do and hard to undo

1 Changing a slug on a live page

It breaks every existing link to that page — bookmarks, Google results, links from other sites. Ask for a redirect first.

2 Deleting instead of unpublishing

Unpublish removes it from the site and keeps it in the Studio. Delete is permanent. When in doubt, unpublish.

3 The Canonical URL field

On the SEO tab. Filling it in incorrectly tells Google to ignore the page. Leave it blank unless a developer has asked you to set it.

4 The Parent Page field on practice areas

It builds the web address. Changing a parent moves the page to a new address — with the same consequences as changing a slug.

5 "Discourage this site from being crawled"

In Global SEO Settings. While it's on, the entire site is invisible to Google. It's on at the moment on purpose, while the site is on a temporary address. Don't switch it without checking — in either direction.

None of this is fragile.

The list above exists so you know where the sharp edges are — not to make you nervous. Everything else in the Studio can be changed, checked on the live site, and changed again. That's what it's for.

14. Common questions

I published, but the site hasn't changed.

Give it two or three minutes — the site rebuilds itself after every publish. If it's still wrong after five, try a hard refresh (**Cmd+Shift+R** or **Ctrl+F5**) to get past your browser's cache.

The Publish button is greyed out.

Either you haven't changed anything, or a required field is empty. Scroll up through the tabs and look for red.

Where do I change the phone number?

Site Settings → **Firm Details**. Once, and it updates everywhere.

I added an attorney but can't find them on the site.

New records go to the bottom of the list. Open **Collections** → **Attorney Bios** and drag them into position.

Can I add a brand-new page?

Not a new *kind* of page — those are built in code. But you can add as many practice areas and location pages as you like, and each of those is a real page with its own address.

I deleted something by mistake.

Stop and ask for help rather than trying to recreate it. The Studio keeps history, and a recent document can usually be recovered — but only if nobody has papered over it in the meantime.

There's a video on a page. Where's the file?

There isn't one. Videos live in Wistia; the Studio only stores the video's ID. The thumbnail and running time are fetched from Wistia automatically.

Something looks broken and I don't think I did it.

Note the page address and roughly when you noticed, and send it on. Don't unpublish the page to hide it — that removes it from Google too, and makes the original problem harder to find.

Still stuck?

Send the page address, what you expected, and what happened instead. Those three things answer almost every question in one reply.